

52 Play & Talk Cards

One play and one talk tip on every card, for babies, toddlers and preschoolers.



▲ 0–1 yr

★ 2–3 yrs

● 3–5 yrs

Copy Cat Faces

NEEDS Just you
 From birth Prep 0 min

Hold baby face to face, c
 see you well. Open wide
 out your tongue. Watch

TALK TIP · REPEAT
 Copy baby's sounds t
 "ba-ba!" Then wait fr

With a grown-up. Sta
 bigger than a toilet-paper w

Color Sort

NEEDS Big blocks in 3 colors,
 From 26 mo Prep 2 min

Put one of each color in a
 child sorts the rest. Mix t
 sort again.

TALK TIP · REPEAT
 "Red" becomes "red t

With a grown-up. Stay
 bigger than a toilet-paj

Box Rocket

NEEDS A big box, crayons
 From 36 mo Prep 5 min Low mess ~15 min

Draw buttons and windows on the box.
 Climb in, count down from ten, and blast
 off to the moon.

TALK TIP · FOLLOW THEIR LEAD
 Ask "Where are we flying? What's out
 the window?"

With a grown-up. Pull out staples and tape first.
 A grown-up stays nearby.

▲ 0–1 year

13 PLAYS

■ 1–2 years

13 PLAYS

★ 2–3 years

13 PLAYS

● 3–5 years

13 PLAYS

Prep: about 20 min to print and cut, once. Most plays: 0–2 min to set up.

Inside this download

- ✓ 54 poker-size cards: 52 plays + how-to + blank
- ✓ No-cut play pages: start today, cut later
- ✓ Every play: start age, prep, mess, 2-min version
- ✓ Make-your-own cards you can type into
- ✓ Grown-up guide with 8 simple talk moves
- ✓ A 52-week play checklist for the fridge

Start here

Five minutes of play and a little back-and-forth talk. That's the whole idea. No screens, no scripts, nothing to get right.

How to use the cards

- 1 Find your child's color.**
Each age has a color and a shape (see the key).
Ages are a guide, not a rule.
- 2 Pick one card.**
Or let your child pick. Keep a few by the door, the tub or the toy basket.
- 3 Gather what you need.**
Almost every play uses things you already have at home.
- 4 Play, then try the talk tip.**
Say it once, then wait. Their look, sound or point is a turn.
- 5 Stay close and stop while it's fun.**
Five happy minutes beats twenty tired ones. Play it again tomorrow.

Age key



0–1 year

CARDS 01–13

Faces, voices, peekaboo, and “what happens if I...?”



1–2 years

CARDS 14–26

Filling, dumping, climbing and first pretend play



2–3 years

CARDS 27–39

Pretend play, sorting, place words and big-paper art



3–5 years

CARDS 40–52

Stories, simple games with rules and taking turns

Every child grows at their own pace. Play any card that fits your child today, younger or older. If you have questions about your child's development, your child's doctor is a good place to start.

The 8 talk moves on the cards



Pause and wait

Count to five in your head before you help. A look, a sound or a point is a turn.



Say what you see

Name what your child is looking at or doing, in short, clear words.



Repeat and add one

Say their word back and add one more: “ball” becomes “big ball.”



Offer a choice

Hold up two options and wait. Pointing is a real answer.



Follow their lead

Play what they choose, and talk about what they care about.



Sing and gesture

Add a tune, a clap or a hand sign. Two ways to join in.



Take turns

You go, they go. Back-and-forth is the whole point.



Wonder aloud

Say “I wonder...” instead of quizzing. Then wait and see.

Why play and talk? Little ones learn to talk by talking with you: a look, a sound, your answer, their turn. Play is full of those moments.

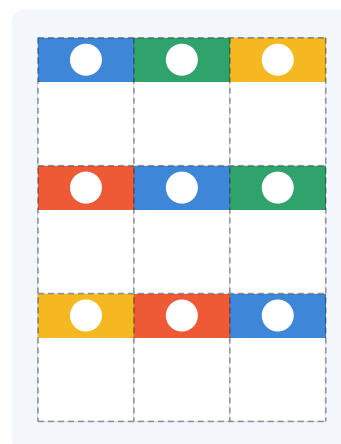
Try: “Your turn!” · “Tell me more.” **Talk, sign, sing and read in the language you know best.** A sign, a point, a tap, or the talk line read word for word: all count.

Most children love 2–3 of these. Repeat the favorites. Tired day? Use the 2-minute versions. Every play works from a chair, a bed or a wheelchair.

BEFORE YOU PRINT

Print, cut and keep

- ✓ **Print at “Actual size” (100%).** Cards are standard poker size, 2.5 × 3.5 in (63.5 × 88.9 mm).
- ✓ **Use cardstock if you can.** Heavy paper or cardstock (65–110 lb / 176–300 gsm) feels like a real deck.
- ✓ **Edges cut off?** Choose “Fit” instead. The cards print a little smaller and still work.
- ✓ **Backs are optional.** Print the backs page on the reverse of a card sheet, flipping on the long edge. Test one sheet first.
- ✓ **Cut on the lines.** A paper trimmer is fastest. Grown-up keeps the pieces and does the cutting. No time? Use the no-cut pages today.
- ✓ **Make them last.** Laminate for sticky fingers. Keep them in a recipe box, a zip bag or on a ring.



9 cards per page · 6 pages · 54 cards
Prep: about 20 minutes to print and cut

✓ Safety basics built into every card

- A grown-up plays along and stays within reach, every time.
- Under 3: every object is bigger than a toilet-paper tube opening (about 1.25 in / 3.2 cm).
- Water play: a grown-up within arm's reach the whole time. Tip the water out after.
- No balloons, no long cords or strings, and no choking-risk foods on any card.
- Check toys and boxes for loose parts, staples and tape before play.
- Grown-up keeps the pieces: the paper cards are for grown-up hands, not for mouths.

Ways to use your deck

Card of the day

Clip one card to the fridge each morning.

Grab-and-go

Keep a few in the diaper bag for waiting rooms.

Share the job

Hand a card to grandparents or the sitter.

Rainy-day pile

Save the indoor plays for stuck-inside days.

License: PERSONAL. You may print and copy this for your own family only (grandparents and sitters who care for your child count as family). No resale, redistribution, sharing, posting, uploading to shared or public drives or websites, or use to train AI. Classroom, center and library licenses are not available yet. Full terms are in the shop's listing and policies.

© 2026 AlphaPlay LLC. Play Before Pixels is a trade name of AlphaPlay LLC. All rights reserved. Version 1.0 · September 2026.

0-1 year: cards 01-07



With a grown-up, every time. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. Card-specific safety notes are on each card and in the rows below.

PLAY

HOW TO PLAY

TIRED DAY • EASIER • HARDER

01 Peekaboo Cloth

From 4 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~5 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A dish towel

Hide your face behind the towel, then pop out: "Peekaboo!" Later, let baby pull it off your head.

Talk: Pause before "boo." A kick, a grin or a squeal is baby's turn.

✓ **Safety:** Put the towel away after play; never leave it in the crib.

2-MINUTE VERSION Hide your face behind your hands: "Where did I go?... Here I am!"

EASIER Hide only half your face so baby can still see you.

HARDER Hide a big toy under the towel and let baby find it.

02 Copy Cat Faces

From birth • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~3 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS Just you

Hold baby face to face, close enough to see you well. Open wide, smile big, stick out your tongue. Watch baby try it too.

Talk: Copy baby's sounds back: "ba" becomes "ba-ba!" Then wait for another.

2-MINUTE VERSION At a diaper change, copy one sound baby makes, then wait.

EASIER Just smile and wait for a smile back.

HARDER Add a sound to each face: "ooh," "ahh," "mmm."

03 Kitchen Drum

From 6 mo • Prep 1 min • No mess • ~5 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A pot and a wooden spoon

Turn the pot upside down on the floor. Tap it, then hand baby the spoon. Take turns: soft, then loud.

Talk: Name the sounds as they happen: "Bang! Bang! Soft... LOUD!"

2-MINUTE VERSION Tap a beat on your knees. Wait for baby to pat too.

EASIER Hold baby's hand and tap the pot together.

HARDER Add a plastic bowl: which one sounds louder?

04 Where's Duck?

From 6 mo • Prep 1 min • No mess • ~5 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A big toy and a towel

Hide the toy under the towel with a little bit showing. Ask "Where's duck?" and let baby find it. Cheer!

Talk: Ask, then count to five in your head before you help.

2-MINUTE VERSION Hide the toy behind your back, then bring it out: "There it is!"

EASIER Leave most of the toy showing.

HARDER Hide it all the way, under one of two towels.

05 Bubble Watch

From 6 mo • Prep 1 min • Low mess • ~5 min

NEEDS Bubbles

Blow a few bubbles slowly above baby. Let baby watch, reach and pop. Blow again when baby reaches, kicks or looks.

Talk: Use the same short words each time: "Up, up... pop!"

✓ **Safety:** You hold the bottle and blow away from baby's face. Wipe little hands.

2-MINUTE VERSION Blow three bubbles and say "pop, pop, pop" as they burst.

EASIER Blow one bubble at a time, slowly.

HARDER Catch a bubble on the wand for baby to poke.

06 Rock and Stop

From birth • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~5 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A song you know

Hold baby and sway while you sing. Stop in the middle and wait. Start again when baby wiggles, coos or looks up.

Talk: The pause is the game. Baby's wiggle means "more!"

2-MINUTE VERSION Sway through one line of any song, then pause.

EASIER Pause for just a second at first.

HARDER Stop at a different spot each time and wait longer.

07 Roll It Back

From 7 mo • Prep 1 min • No mess • ~5 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A big soft ball

For babies who can sit: sit facing each other, legs apart. Roll the ball to baby, then help roll it back.

Talk: Say "Ready... roll!" and wait for a look, a sound or a reach.

2-MINUTE VERSION Roll the ball once from your lap into baby's hands.

EASIER Sit close together, just a short roll apart.

HARDER Scoot back a little farther after each roll.

Start ages are a guide, never a deadline: every child grows at their own pace. Questions about your child's development? Your child's doctor is a good place to start.

0-1 year: cards 08-13



With a grown-up, every time. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. Card-specific safety notes are on each card and in the rows below.

PLAY

HOW TO PLAY

TIRED DAY • EASIER • HARDER

08 **First Book Chat**

From 3 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~5 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A board book

Sit baby on your lap. Point to one picture and name it. Let baby pat the pictures and help turn the pages.

Talk: Talk about whatever baby looks at, even the same page again.

2-MINUTE VERSION Name one picture on one page, then close the book.

EASIER Stay on one page and let baby pat it.

HARDER Ask “Where’s the dog?” and wait for a look or a point.

09 **In and Out**

From 8 mo • Prep 1 min • Low mess • ~5 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A basket and 4–5 big toys

Drop toys into the basket one by one: “In!” Tip them out: “Out!” Let baby dump and fill.

Talk: One word for each move: “in,” “out,” “all gone!”

2-MINUTE VERSION Drop one toy in: “In!” Tip it out: “Out!”

EASIER Use one toy and a wide basket.

HARDER Use a box with a smaller opening (big toys only).

10 **Leaf Hello**

From 3 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~5 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A tree or a big plant

Carry baby close to a tree or a window plant. Touch a leaf together, look up at the sky, feel the breeze.

Talk: Name it, then add one word: “Leaf. Green leaf. Soft leaf.”

✓ Safety: Stay within reach. Leaves and petals stay out of mouths.

2-MINUTE VERSION Stand at a window and name one thing outside.

EASIER Just look up and feel the breeze together.

HARDER Touch two leaves: big and small, smooth and bumpy.

11 **Tickle Countdown**

From 4 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~3 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS Just you

Wiggle your fingers in the air: “One... two... three...” then a gentle tickle. Do it again, a little slower.

Talk: Stop at “two...” A squeal or a kick asks for “three!”

✓ Safety: Gentle tickles only. If baby turns away, stop: that’s a turn too.

2-MINUTE VERSION One slow countdown, one gentle tickle, then a cuddle.

EASIER Skip the countdown: wiggle your fingers, then tickle.

HARDER Pause longer at “two...” and wait for baby to ask.

12 **Stack and Crash**

From 6 mo • Prep 1 min • Low mess • ~5 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS Plastic cups or big blocks

Stack three cups into a tower. Let baby knock it over. Cheer, and build it again together.

Talk: Say “up, up, up... crash!” and throw your arms wide on “crash.”

2-MINUTE VERSION Stack two cups and let baby knock them over.

EASIER Stack just two cups.

HARDER Help baby put a cup on top before the crash.

13 **Sock Off!**

From 6 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~3 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A clean grown-up sock

Slip a big, loose sock halfway onto baby’s foot. Let baby pull it off: “Sock off!” Try the other foot.

Talk: Say it as it happens: “Foot! Sock on... sock off!”

✓ Safety: Stay within reach. Put the sock away after play; socks stay out of mouths.

2-MINUTE VERSION At a diaper change, say each step: “Sock off. Sock on.”

EASIER Pull the sock most of the way off first.

HARDER Slip it over baby’s hand instead: “Where did your hand go?”

Start ages are a guide, never a deadline: every child grows at their own pace. Questions about your child’s development? Your child’s doctor is a good place to start.

1–2 years: cards 14–20



With a grown-up, every time. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. Card-specific safety notes are on each card and in the rows below.

PLAY

HOW TO PLAY

TIRED DAY • EASIER • HARDER

14 **Box Car**

From 12 mo • Prep 3 min • No mess •
~10 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A big cardboard box

Your toddler sits in the box. Push it slowly around the room. Stop at “stations” to wave hello.

Talk: Say “Ready, set...” and wait for “go!” Any sound counts.

✓ **Safety:** Push slowly on the floor. Pull out staples and tape first.

2-MINUTE VERSION Sit in the box together and pretend to drive: “Beep beep!”

EASIER Push slowly in a straight line.

HARDER Let them push a teddy in the box over to you.

15 **Stir the Soup**

From 12 mo • Prep 1 min • Low mess •
~10 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A pot, a big spoon, big blocks

Drop blocks into the pot and stir. Blow on the “hot” soup. Serve a spoonful to a teddy.

Talk: Ask “Hot soup or cold soup?” Hold up two hands and wait.

2-MINUTE VERSION Hand over a spoon and an empty pot. Taste it: “Mmm!”

EASIER Just drop the blocks in and take them out.

HARDER Ask for two “ingredients”: a red block and a blue one.

16 **Animal Voices**

From 12 mo • Prep 1 min • No mess •
~5 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS Big toy animals or a picture book

Hold up an animal and make its sound. Pass it to your child. Swap animals and go again.

Talk: Say “The cow says...” and leave a gap for “moo.”

2-MINUTE VERSION Make one animal sound and wait for them to copy.

EASIER Use one animal they know well.

HARDER Make the sound and let them find the animal.

17 **Pour and Splash**

From 12 mo • Prep 3 min • Messy •
~10 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A tub of water, 2 plastic cups

Set the tub on a towel. Pour water from cup to cup. Let your child pour, splash and fill.

Talk: Talk as it happens: “Full... empty! Pour, pour.”

✓ **Safety:** Water play: a grown-up within arm’s reach the whole time. Tip the water out after.

2-MINUTE VERSION At bath time, with you right there, pour water from cup to cup: “Pour!”

EASIER Fill the cups halfway so they stay light.

HARDER Add a colander or a funnel to pour through.

18 **Block Tower**

From 14 mo • Prep 1 min • Low mess •
~5 min

NEEDS Big blocks

Build a tower together, one block each. Count as you go. Let them knock it down and start again.

Talk: They say “block,” you say “big block!”

2-MINUTE VERSION Stack two blocks and knock them down together.

EASIER Use empty boxes: big and light.

HARDER Count each block out loud as it goes on.

19 **Hat Parade**

From 12 mo • Prep 2 min • No mess •
~5 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS 3–4 hats from around the house

Try on hats in front of a mirror. Make a silly face in each one. March around the room.

Talk: Ask “Sun hat or winter hat?” Let them choose yours too.

✓ **Safety:** Only hats with no ties, cords or pom-poms. Stay within reach.

2-MINUTE VERSION Put one hat on your head: “Hat!” Let them pull it off.

EASIER Use one hat and the mirror.

HARDER Let them choose a hat for each teddy.

20 **Pillow Mountain**

From 12 mo • Prep 2 min • Low mess •
~10 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS Couch cushions

Pile the cushions on the floor to make a mountain. Help your child climb up, then slide down.

Talk: Say it as they move: “Up, up, up! Down!”

✓ **Safety:** On the floor, away from furniture corners. Stay within reach.

2-MINUTE VERSION Lie on the floor and let them climb over your legs.

EASIER Two cushions only, low and flat.

HARDER Add a crawl-under “cave” between two cushions.

Start ages are a guide, never a deadline: every child grows at their own pace. Questions about your child’s development? Your child’s doctor is a good place to start.

1–2 years: cards 21–26



With a grown-up, every time. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. Card-specific safety notes are on each card and in the rows below.

PLAY

HOW TO PLAY

TIRED DAY • EASIER • HARDER

21 **Sock Toss**

From 15 mo • Prep 1 min • Low mess •
~5 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS Rolled-up pairs of socks, a basket

Toss the sock balls into the basket. Find a big one and a little one. Balance one on your head!

Talk: “Sock” becomes “big sock!” or “red sock!”

2-MINUTE VERSION Toss three sock balls into the basket together.

EASIER Put the basket right next to them.

HARDER Step back one big step after each throw.

22 **Teddy's Bedtime**

From 15 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess •
~5 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A stuffed toy, a small towel

Tuck teddy in with the towel. Read teddy a book, sing teddy a song, whisper “night-night.”

Talk: If they feed teddy instead, talk about the snack.

2-MINUTE VERSION Tuck teddy in and whisper “night-night” together.

EASIER Just cover teddy with the towel.

HARDER Let them choose teddy's book and teddy's song.

23 **Chair Tunnel**

From 12 mo • Prep 3 min • No mess •
~10 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS Two chairs and a blanket

Drape the blanket over two chairs to make a tunnel. Crawl through together, then take turns.

Talk: Say the word as they move: “In... through... out!”

✓ Safety: Use sturdy chairs that won't tip. Stay within reach.

2-MINUTE VERSION Crawl under the table together: “In... out!”

EASIER Make it short: one chair and the blanket.

HARDER Add a pillow to crawl over at the end.

24 **Clap and Stomp**

From 12 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess •
~3 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS Just you

Clap twice, stomp twice, pat your knees. Let your child copy you, then you copy their moves.

Talk: Copy whatever they do. They're the leader now.

2-MINUTE VERSION Clap twice, wait, and see if they clap back.

EASIER Do one move at a time.

HARDER Do two moves in a row: clap, then stomp.

25 **Pull-Out Box**

From 12 mo • Prep 2 min • Low mess •
~5 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS An empty tissue box, 6 washcloths

Stuff the washcloths into the box. Your child pulls them out one by one. Stuff them back in and go again.

Talk: Hold one up: “More?” Wait for a look, a point or a sound.

✓ Safety: Pull out the plastic film from the box opening first. Stay within reach.

2-MINUTE VERSION Tuck a washcloth in your sleeve and let them pull it out.

EASIER Leave the cloths sticking out a little.

HARDER Ask them to stuff the cloths back in and hand you the box.

26 **Kick and Chase**

From 15 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess •
~10 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A big soft ball

Roll or kick the ball across the room. Race to it together. Catch it and sit on it!

Talk: Ask “Kick it or roll it?” Show both, then wait.

2-MINUTE VERSION Roll the ball to them from where you sit.

EASIER Roll it gently, a short way.

HARDER Kick it toward a “goal” between two cushions.

Start ages are a guide, never a deadline: every child grows at their own pace. Questions about your child's development? Your child's doctor is a good place to start.

★ 2–3 years: cards 27–33

✓ **With a grown-up, every time.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. Card-specific safety notes are on each card and in the rows below.

PLAY

HOW TO PLAY

TIRED DAY • EASIER • HARDER

27 **Blanket Fort**

From 24 mo • Prep 5 min • Low mess • ~15 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A blanket, chairs, pillows

Build a fort together. Bring in a book and a teddy. Read inside, then peek out the door.

Talk: Use place words: “in,” “under,” “on top,” “behind.”

✓ **Safety:** Sturdy chairs only; nothing heavy on top. Stay within reach.

2-MINUTE VERSION Drape a blanket over the table and read one book under it.

EASIER One blanket over one chair.

HARDER Add a door flap and a secret knock.

28 **Tea Party**

From 24 mo • Prep 2 min • No mess • ~10 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS Plastic cups and plates, stuffed toys

Set a pretend table for the toys. Pour pretend tea, pass pretend cake, and clink cups: “Cheers!”

Talk: Ask as Bear: “More tea? Milk or honey?” Wait for the answer.

2-MINUTE VERSION Pour pretend tea for one toy and say “Cheers!”

EASIER One cup and one toy.

HARDER Let them take each toy’s order.

29 **Color Sort**

From 26 mo • Prep 2 min • Low mess • ~10 min

NEEDS Big blocks in 3 colors, 3 bowls

Put one of each color in a bowl. Your child sorts the rest. Mix them all up and sort again.

Talk: “Red” becomes “red block goes here!”

2-MINUTE VERSION Sort a few grown-up socks: dark ones, light ones.

EASIER Start with just two colors.

HARDER Add a fourth color, or sort by size too.

30 **Car Ramp**

From 24 mo • Prep 2 min • No mess • ~10 min

NEEDS A board or big book, big toy cars

Prop the board on the sofa to make a ramp. Race the cars down. Which one goes the farthest?

Talk: Say what happens: “Fast! Slow! Crash!”

✓ **Safety:** Only cars bigger than a toilet-paper tube, with no loose wheels.

2-MINUTE VERSION Tilt a big book and let one car roll down.

EASIER Keep the ramp low.

HARDER Guess which car will go farther, then test it.

31 **Big Paper Art**

From 24 mo • Prep 2 min • Low mess • ~10 min

NEEDS Big paper, jumbo egg-shaped crayons, tape

Tape the paper to the floor. Draw lines, dots and circles side by side. Swap crayons now and then.

Talk: Describe, don’t quiz: “Round and round. A big circle!”

✓ **Safety:** Crayons too big to fit in a toilet-paper tube. Toss broken bits.

2-MINUTE VERSION Draw one big circle together, then add two eyes.

EASIER One color, big lines.

HARDER Take turns: you draw a line, they add to it.

32 **Freeze Dance**

From 24 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~5 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A song to sing or play

Dance to a song. When the music stops, freeze! Take turns being the one who stops the music.

Talk: Let your child shout “stop!” and “go!” for you.

2-MINUTE VERSION Sing one line, stop, and freeze together.

EASIER Freeze for just a second.

HARDER Freeze in a shape: tall, tiny or wide.

33 **Sock Friend Chat**

From 24 mo • Prep 2 min • No mess • ~5 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A clean grown-up sock, a marker (yours)

Draw eyes on the sock and slip it on your hand. Your sock friend says hello, asks a question, then waits.

Talk: Sock friends are patient. Give extra time to answer.

✓ **Safety:** Draw the face on: no buttons or stick-on eyes. You keep the marker.

2-MINUTE VERSION Put your hand in a sock and say hello in a squeaky voice.

EASIER The sock friend just waves and says hello.

HARDER Make two sock friends and let them talk to each other.

Start ages are a guide, never a deadline: every child grows at their own pace. Questions about your child’s development? Your child’s doctor is a good place to start.

★ 2–3 years: cards 34–39

✓ **With a grown-up, every time.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. Card-specific safety notes are on each card and in the rows below.

PLAY

HOW TO PLAY

TIRED DAY • EASIER • HARDER

34 **Nature Basket**

From 24 mo • Prep 0 min • Low mess • ~15 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A basket, a walk outside

Collect big leaves, sticks and pinecones. At home, sort them: bumpy, smooth, big, small.

Talk: Name how they feel: “Bumpy pinecone. Smooth stick.”

✓ **Safety:** Only things bigger than a toilet-paper tube. No berries or mushrooms. Wash hands after.

2-MINUTE VERSION On your next walk, pick up one big leaf and name its color.

EASIER Collect only leaves.

HARDER Sort by two things: big and bumpy, small and smooth.

35 **Pretend Shop**

From 26 mo • Prep 3 min • Low mess • ~15 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS Empty food boxes, a bag

Set up a shop on the sofa. Your child fills the bag and pays you with a high five. Then swap jobs.

Talk: Ask “Cereal or crackers today?” and wait.

2-MINUTE VERSION Hold out your hand: “One apple, please!” Pay with a high five.

EASIER Just fill the bag and carry it.

HARDER Ask for amounts: “Two boxes, please.”

36 **Toy Bath**

From 24 mo • Prep 3 min • Messy • ~10 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A tub of water, a washable toy, a cloth

Give the toy a bath: wash its hands, feet and tummy. Dry it off and tuck it in.

Talk: Name body parts: “Wash the toes. Now the knees!”

✓ **Safety:** Water play: a grown-up within arm's reach the whole time. Tip the water out after.

2-MINUTE VERSION Wipe a toy's feet with a damp cloth: “Scrub, scrub!”

EASIER Use a damp cloth instead of a tub.

HARDER Ask “What should we wash next?” and let them choose.

37 **Animal Moves**

From 24 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~5 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS Space to move

Hop like a frog, stomp like an elephant, tiptoe like a cat. Take turns picking the animal.

Talk: Add the sound and the move: “Hop, hop, ribbit!”

2-MINUTE VERSION Pick one animal and hop like a frog three times.

EASIER Copy your moves, slowly.

HARDER Guess the animal from the move alone.

38 **Shape Hunt**

From 30 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~10 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS Just you

Walk around the house looking for circles: a plate, a clock, a wheel. Then hunt for squares.

Talk: Point and name: “Round, like the clock!”

2-MINUTE VERSION Find one circle in the room you're sitting in.

EASIER Hunt for circles only.

HARDER Hunt for triangles too.

39 **Little Helper**

From 24 mo • Prep 1 min • Low mess • ~5 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A cloth damp with plain water

Wipe the table together after a meal. Then let your child wipe a chair, then a toy.

Talk: Talk as you work: “Wipe, wipe. All clean!”

✓ **Safety:** Plain water only: no sprays or wipes. Stay within reach.

2-MINUTE VERSION Hand over the cloth for one wipe of the table: “All clean!”

EASIER Give them one spot to wipe.

HARDER Wipe, then set out the spoons for dinner.

Start ages are a guide, never a deadline: every child grows at their own pace. Questions about your child's development? Your child's doctor is a good place to start.

3–5 years: cards 40–46



With a grown-up, every time. A grown-up plays along and stays nearby. Card-specific safety notes are on each card and in the rows below.

PLAY

HOW TO PLAY

TIRED DAY • EASIER • HARDER

40 **Story Box**

From 36 mo • Prep 2 min • No mess •
~10 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A box, 3 toys from around the house

Pull out 3 toys. Make up a story that uses all three. Take turns adding one sentence each.

Talk: Let the story go anywhere. Ask, “And then what?”

2-MINUTE VERSION Tell a one-minute story about any toy in the room.

EASIER Use one toy and ask “What happened next?”

HARDER Add a problem: “Uh-oh! Then what?”

41 **Obstacle Course**

From 36 mo • Prep 5 min • Low mess •
~15 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS Pillows, a chair, a blanket

Build a course: crawl under the chair, hop over the pillows, roll across the blanket.

Talk: Give two-step directions: “Crawl under, then jump!” Then swap.

✓ Safety: Clear the space of sharp corners. A grown-up stays nearby.

2-MINUTE VERSION Two steps only: crawl under the table, then hop.

EASIER Just one or two steps.

HARDER Give three-step directions, then swap who gives them.

42 **I Spy Colors**

From 36 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess •
~5 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS Just you

“I spy something green.” Your child guesses. Then they pick something and give you the clue.

Talk: If they get stuck, add a hint: “It’s round...”

2-MINUTE VERSION One round of “I spy something blue.”

EASIER Point to the area while you give the clue.

HARDER Spy by sound: “something that starts with b.”

43 **Restaurant**

From 36 mo • Prep 5 min • Low mess •
~15 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS Paper, crayons, plates

Draw a menu together. Your child takes your order, “cooks” it and brings it to the table. Swap roles.

Talk: Ask “Soup or pizza? Anything else?”

2-MINUTE VERSION Ask “What’s on the menu tonight?” and order from your chair.

EASIER Skip the menu; just take your order.

HARDER Let them “write” the order and bring the bill.

44 **Box Rocket**

From 36 mo • Prep 5 min • Low mess •
~15 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A big box, crayons

Draw buttons and windows on the box. Climb in, count down from ten, and blast off to the moon.

Talk: Ask “Where are we flying? What’s out the window?”

✓ Safety: Pull out staples and tape first. A grown-up stays nearby.

2-MINUTE VERSION Sit on the floor, count down from five and blast off with your arms.

EASIER Count down from five.

HARDER Plan the trip: what do we pack for the moon?

45 **Kitchen List**

From 42 mo • Prep 2 min • No mess •
~10 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS Paper, a crayon

Draw a list together: an apple, a cup, a spoon. Hunt for each one in the kitchen and check it off.

Talk: “Found the spoon! What’s next on our list?”

✓ Safety: You choose the list. Knives, the stove and cleaners stay off it.

2-MINUTE VERSION Name three things to find in the room you’re in.

EASIER Draw just two things.

HARDER Add one tricky item: “something round.”

46 **Do What I Do**

From 36 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess •
~5 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS Just you

Touch your nose, hop on one foot, spin around once. Your child copies. Then they’re the leader.

Talk: Being the leader means practicing clear directions.

2-MINUTE VERSION Touch your nose and wait for them to copy. Then swap.

EASIER One move at a time.

HARDER Two moves in a row: “Clap, then spin.”

Start ages are a guide, never a deadline: every child grows at their own pace. Questions about your child’s development? Your child’s doctor is a good place to start.

3–5 years: cards 47–52

✓ **With a grown-up, every time.** A grown-up plays along and stays nearby. Card-specific safety notes are on each card and in the rows below.

PLAY

HOW TO PLAY

TIRED DAY • EASIER • HARDER

47 **Shadow Animals**

From 36 mo • Prep 2 min • No mess •
~10 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A flashlight, a wall

Dim the lights. Shine the flashlight on a wall and make hand shadows: a bird, a dog, a crocodile.

Talk: Ask “What animal is this?” Let them guess, then try a new one.

✓ **Safety:** A grown-up holds the flashlight. Battery covers stay shut.

2-MINUTE VERSION Make one hand shadow with the flashlight and let them name it.

EASIER Wiggle your hand and let them chase the shadow.

HARDER Make up a short shadow story together.

48 **Book Bridge**

From 36 mo • Prep 3 min • Low mess •
~10 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS Books or blocks, toy cars

Build a bridge between two stacks. Drive cars over it. Make it longer. Will it hold?

Talk: Say “I wonder if it will hold?” Then wait and see.

2-MINUTE VERSION Lay one book across two stacks and drive one car over.

EASIER Keep the stacks low.

HARDER Make it longer. How many books before it falls?

49 **Sock Match**

From 36 mo • Prep 1 min • Low mess •
~10 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A pile of clean socks

Dump the socks out. Race to find matching pairs. Roll each pair into a ball.

Talk: Hold up two: “Same or different?”

2-MINUTE VERSION Find one matching pair in the laundry basket.

EASIER Start with 3 pairs that look very different.

HARDER Race: who finds the most pairs?

50 **Water Painting**

From 36 mo • Prep 2 min • Low mess •
~15 min

NEEDS A cup of water, a paintbrush

Outside, “paint” a fence, a step or the sidewalk with water. Watch the picture dry and disappear.

Talk: “Where did it go? I wonder if the sun dried it.”

✓ **Safety:** Water play: a grown-up within arm’s reach, away from the street.

2-MINUTE VERSION Dip your fingers in a cup and paint one line on a step.

EASIER Paint with fingers instead of a brush.

HARDER Paint a shape and guess each other’s.

51 **Feelings Faces**

From 36 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess •
~5 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A wall mirror or an unbreakable one

Make faces in the mirror together: happy, sad, surprised, grumpy. Guess each other’s face.

Talk: “Your eyebrows went up. Surprised!” Ask when they felt that way.

✓ **Safety:** Use a wall mirror or an unbreakable one. A grown-up stays nearby.

2-MINUTE VERSION Make one face and let them guess it.

EASIER Try only happy and sad.

HARDER Act out what made you feel that way.

52 **Sound Walk**

From 36 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess •
~15 min • **nothing to buy**

NEEDS A walk outside

Stand still and listen. Count sounds on your fingers: a bird, a car, the wind. Walk on and listen again.

Talk: Whisper “What do you hear?” Take turns naming sounds.

✓ **Safety:** Hold hands near the street. A grown-up stays close.

2-MINUTE VERSION Open a window and count three sounds together.

EASIER Count just two sounds, or two things that move.

HARDER Stand still, close your eyes and guess each sound.

Start ages are a guide, never a deadline: every child grows at their own pace. Questions about your child’s development? Your child’s doctor is a good place to start.

START HERE

How to play

- 1 Find your child's color.
- 2 Pick a card, or let your child pick.
- 3 Play while it's fun. Stop before it isn't.
- 4 Try the talk tip. Then wait.

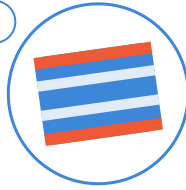
▲ 0–1 year ■ 1–2 years
★ 2–3 years ● 3–5 years



✓ Every card: a grown-up plays along and stays within reach.

Version 1.0 · September 2026

▲ 0–1 yr



01

Peekaboo Cloth

NEEDS A dish towel

👤 From 4 mo ⏱ Prep 0 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

Hide your face behind the towel, then pop out: “Peekaboo!” Later, let baby pull it off your head.

💬 TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT

Pause before “boo.” A kick, a grin or a squeal is baby's turn.

✓ With a grown-up. Put the towel away after play; never leave it in the crib.

▲ 0–1 yr



02

Copy Cat Faces

NEEDS Just you

👤 From birth ⏱ Prep 0 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~3 min

Hold baby face to face, close enough to see you well. Open wide, smile big, stick out your tongue. Watch baby try it too.

💬 TALK TIP · REPEAT AND ADD ONE

Copy baby's sounds back: “ba” becomes “ba-ba!” Then wait for another.

✓ With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr



03

Kitchen Drum

NEEDS A pot and a wooden spoon

👤 From 6 mo ⏱ Prep 1 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

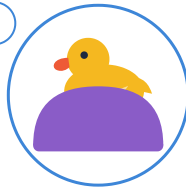
Turn the pot upside down on the floor. Tap it, then hand baby the spoon. Take turns: soft, then loud.

💬 TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Name the sounds as they happen: “Bang! Bang! Soft... LOUD!”

✓ With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr



04

Where's Duck?

NEEDS A big toy and a towel

👤 From 6 mo ⏱ Prep 1 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

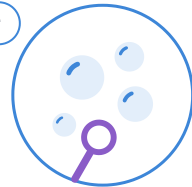
Hide the toy under the towel with a little bit showing. Ask “Where's duck?” and let baby find it. Cheer!

💬 TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT

Ask, then count to five in your head before you help.

✓ With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr



05

Bubble Watch

NEEDS Bubbles

👤 From 6 mo ⏱ Prep 1 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~5 min

Blow a few bubbles slowly above baby. Let baby watch, reach and pop. Blow again when baby reaches, kicks or looks.

💬 TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Use the same short words each time: “Up, up... pop!”

✓ With a grown-up. You hold the bottle and blow away from baby's face. Wipe little hands.

▲ 0–1 yr



06

Rock and Stop

NEEDS A song you know

👤 From birth ⏱ Prep 0 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

Hold baby and sway while you sing. Stop in the middle and wait. Start again when baby wiggles, coos or looks up.

💬 TALK TIP · SING AND GESTURE

The pause is the game. Baby's wiggle means “more!”

✓ With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr



07

Roll It Back

NEEDS A big soft ball

👤 From 7 mo ⏱ Prep 1 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

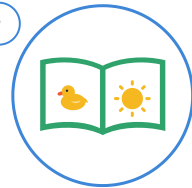
For babies who can sit: sit facing each other, legs apart. Roll the ball to baby, then help roll it back.

💬 TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT

Say “Ready... roll!” and wait for a look, a sound or a reach.

✓ With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr



08

First Book Chat

NEEDS A board book

👤 From 3 mo ⏱ Prep 0 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

Sit baby on your lap. Point to one picture and name it. Let baby pat the pictures and help turn the pages.

💬 TALK TIP · FOLLOW THEIR LEAD

Talk about whatever baby looks at, even the same page again.

✓ With a grown-up. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr



09

In and Out

NEEDS A basket and 4–5 big toys

👤 From 8 mo ⚙️ Prep 1 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~5 min

Drop toys into the basket one by one: “In!” Tip them out: “Out!” Let baby dump and fill.

TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

One word for each move: “in,” “out,” “all gone!”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr



10

Leaf Hello

NEEDS A tree or a big plant

👤 From 3 mo ⚙️ Prep 0 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

Carry baby close to a tree or a window plant. Touch a leaf together, look up at the sky, feel the breeze.

TALK TIP · REPEAT AND ADD ONE

Name it, then add one word: “Leaf. Green leaf. Soft leaf.”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Leaves and petals stay out of mouths.

▲ 0–1 yr



11

Tickle Countdown

NEEDS Just you

👤 From 4 mo ⚙️ Prep 0 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~3 min

Wiggle your fingers in the air: “One... two... three...” then a gentle tickle. Do it again, a little slower.

TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT

Stop at “two...” A squeal or a kick asks for “three!”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Gentle tickles only. If baby turns away, stop: that’s a turn too.

▲ 0–1 yr



12

Stack and Crash

NEEDS Plastic cups or big blocks

👤 From 6 mo ⚙️ Prep 1 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~5 min

Stack three cups into a tower. Let baby knock it over. Cheer, and build it again together.

TALK TIP · SING AND GESTURE

Say “up, up, up... crash!” and throw your arms wide on “crash.”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr



13

Sock Off!

NEEDS A clean grown-up sock

👤 From 6 mo ⚙️ Prep 0 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~3 min

Slip a big, loose sock halfway onto baby’s foot. Let baby pull it off: “Sock off!” Try the other foot.

TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Say it as it happens: “Foot! Sock on... sock off!”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Put the sock away after play; socks stay out of mouths.

■ 1–2 yrs



14

Box Car

NEEDS A big cardboard box

👤 From 12 mo ⚙️ Prep 3 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~10 min

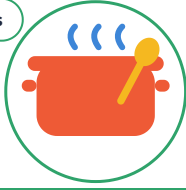
Your toddler sits in the box. Push it slowly around the room. Stop at “stations” to wave hello.

TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT

Say “Ready, set...” and wait for “go!” Any sound counts.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Push slowly on the floor. Pull out staples and tape first.

■ 1–2 yrs



15

Stir the Soup

NEEDS A pot, a big spoon, big blocks

👤 From 12 mo ⚙️ Prep 1 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~10 min

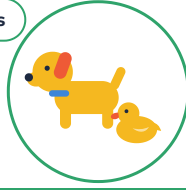
Drop blocks into the pot and stir. Blow on the “hot” soup. Serve a spoonful to a teddy.

TALK TIP · OFFER A CHOICE

Ask “Hot soup or cold soup?” Hold up two hands and wait.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

■ 1–2 yrs



16

Animal Voices

NEEDS Big toy animals or a picture book

👤 From 12 mo ⚙️ Prep 1 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

Hold up an animal and make its sound. Pass it to your child. Swap animals and go again.

TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT

Say “The cow says...” and leave a gap for “moo.”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

■ 1–2 yrs



17

Pour and Splash

NEEDS A tub of water, 2 plastic cups

👤 From 12 mo ⚙️ Prep 3 min 💧 Messy ⌚ ~10 min

Set the tub on a towel. Pour water from cup to cup. Let your child pour, splash and fill.

TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Talk as it happens: “Full... empty! Pour, pour.”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Water play: a grown-up within arm’s reach the whole time. Tip the water out after.

1-2 yrs



18

Block Tower

NEEDS Big blocks

From 14 mo Prep 1 min Low mess ~5 min

Build a tower together, one block each. Count as you go. Let them knock it down and start again.

TALK TIP · REPEAT AND ADD ONE
They say “block,” you say “big block!”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

1-2 yrs



19

Hat Parade

NEEDS 3-4 hats from around the house

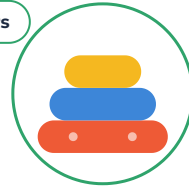
From 12 mo Prep 2 min No mess ~5 min

Try on hats in front of a mirror. Make a silly face in each one. March around the room.

TALK TIP · OFFER A CHOICE
Ask “Sun hat or winter hat?” Let them choose yours too.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Only hats with no ties, cords or pom-poms. Stay within reach.

1-2 yrs



20

Pillow Mountain

NEEDS Couch cushions

From 12 mo Prep 2 min Low mess ~10 min

Pile the cushions on the floor to make a mountain. Help your child climb up, then slide down.

TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE
Say it as they move: “Up, up, up! Down!”

✓ **With a grown-up.** On the floor, away from furniture corners. Stay within reach.

1-2 yrs



21

Sock Toss

NEEDS Rolled-up pairs of socks, a basket

From 15 mo Prep 1 min Low mess ~5 min

Toss the sock balls into the basket. Find a big one and a little one. Balance one on your head!

TALK TIP · REPEAT AND ADD ONE
“Sock” becomes “big sock!” or “red sock!”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

1-2 yrs



22

Teddy's Bedtime

NEEDS A stuffed toy, a small towel

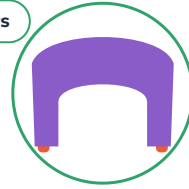
From 15 mo Prep 0 min No mess ~5 min

Tuck teddy in with the towel. Read teddy a book, sing teddy a song, whisper “night-night.”

TALK TIP · FOLLOW THEIR LEAD
If they feed teddy instead, talk about the snack.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

1-2 yrs



23

Chair Tunnel

NEEDS Two chairs and a blanket

From 12 mo Prep 3 min No mess ~10 min

Drape the blanket over two chairs to make a tunnel. Crawl through together, then take turns.

TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE
Say the word as they move: “In... through... out!”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Use sturdy chairs that won't tip. Stay within reach.

1-2 yrs



24

Clap and Stomp

NEEDS Just you

From 12 mo Prep 0 min No mess ~3 min

Clap twice, stomp twice, pat your knees. Let your child copy you, then you copy their moves.

TALK TIP · FOLLOW THEIR LEAD
Copy whatever they do. They're the leader now.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

1-2 yrs



25

Pull-Out Box

NEEDS An empty tissue box, 6 washcloths

From 12 mo Prep 2 min Low mess ~5 min

Stuff the washcloths into the box. Your child pulls them out one by one. Stuff them back in and go again.

TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT
Hold one up: “More?” Wait for a look, a point or a sound.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Pull out the plastic film from the box opening first. Stay within reach.

1-2 yrs



26

Kick and Chase

NEEDS A big soft ball

From 15 mo Prep 0 min No mess ~10 min

Roll or kick the ball across the room. Race to it together. Catch it and sit on it!

TALK TIP · OFFER A CHOICE
Ask “Kick it or roll it?” Show both, then wait.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

★ 2–3 yrs



27

Blanket Fort

NEEDS A blanket, chairs, pillows

👤 From 24 mo ⚙️ Prep 5 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~15 min

Build a fort together. Bring in a book and a teddy. Read inside, then peek out the door.

TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Use place words: “in,” “under,” “on top,” “behind.”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Sturdy chairs only; nothing heavy on top. Stay within reach.

★ 2–3 yrs



28

Tea Party

NEEDS Plastic cups and plates, stuffed toys

👤 From 24 mo ⚙️ Prep 2 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~10 min

Set a pretend table for the toys. Pour pretend tea, pass pretend cake, and clink cups: “Cheers!”

TALK TIP · OFFER A CHOICE

Ask as Bear: “More tea? Milk or honey?” Wait for the answer.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

★ 2–3 yrs



29

Color Sort

NEEDS Big blocks in 3 colors, 3 bowls

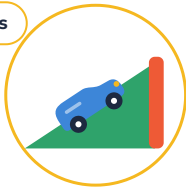
👤 From 26 mo ⚙️ Prep 2 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~10 min

Put one of each color in a bowl. Your child sorts the rest. Mix them all up and sort again.

🗨️ **TALK TIP · REPEAT AND ADD ONE**
“Red” becomes “red block goes here!”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

★ 2–3 yrs



30

Car Ramp

NEEDS A board or big book, big toy cars

👤 From 24 mo ⚙️ Prep 2 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~10 min

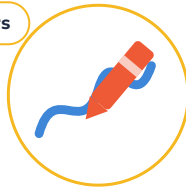
Prop the board on the sofa to make a ramp. Race the cars down. Which one goes the farthest?

TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Say what happens: “Fast! Slow! Crash!”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Only cars bigger than a toilet-paper tube, with no loose wheels.

★ 2–3 yrs



31

Big Paper Art

NEEDS Big paper, jumbo egg-shaped crayons, tape

👤 From 24 mo ⚙️ Prep 2 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~10 min

Tape the paper to the floor. Draw lines, dots and circles side by side. Swap crayons now and then.

TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Describe, don't quiz: “Round and round. A big circle!”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Crayons too big to fit in a toilet-paper tube. Toss broken bits.

★ 2–3 yrs



32

Freeze Dance

NEEDS A song to sing or play

👤 From 24 mo ⚙️ Prep 0 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

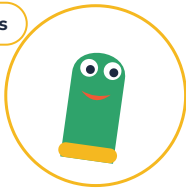
Dance to a song. When the music stops, freeze! Take turns being the one who stops the music.

TALK TIP · FOLLOW THEIR LEAD

Let your child shout “stop!” and “go!” for you.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

★ 2–3 yrs



33

Sock Friend Chat

NEEDS A clean grown-up sock, a marker (yours)

👤 From 24 mo ⚙️ Prep 2 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

Draw eyes on the sock and slip it on your hand. Your sock friend says hello, asks a question, then waits.

TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT

Sock friends are patient. Give extra time to answer.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Draw the face on: no buttons or stick-on eyes. You keep the marker.

★ 2–3 yrs



34

Nature Basket

NEEDS A basket, a walk outside

👤 From 24 mo ⚙️ Prep 0 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~15 min

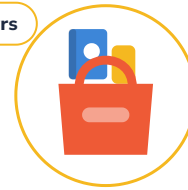
Collect big leaves, sticks and pinecones. At home, sort them: bumpy, smooth, big, small.

TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Name how they feel: “Bumpy pinecone. Smooth stick.”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Only things bigger than a toilet-paper tube. No berries or mushrooms. Wash hands after.

★ 2–3 yrs



35

Pretend Shop

NEEDS Empty food boxes, a bag

👤 From 26 mo ⚙️ Prep 3 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~15 min

Set up a shop on the sofa. Your child fills the bag and pays you with a high five. Then swap jobs.

TALK TIP · OFFER A CHOICE

Ask “Cereal or crackers today?” and wait.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

★ 2–3 yrs



36

Toy Bath

NEEDS A tub of water, a washable toy, a cloth

👤 From 24 mo 🔄 Prep 3 min 💧 Messy ⌚ ~10 min

Give the toy a bath: wash its hands, feet and tummy. Dry it off and tuck it in.

TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Name body parts: "Wash the toes. Now the knees!"

✓ **With a grown-up.** Water play: a grown-up within arm's reach the whole time. Tip the water out after.

★ 2–3 yrs



37

Animal Moves

NEEDS Space to move

👤 From 24 mo 🔄 Prep 0 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

Hop like a frog, stomp like an elephant, tiptoe like a cat. Take turns picking the animal.

TALK TIP · SING AND GESTURE

Add the sound and the move: "Hop, hop, rabbit!"

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

★ 2–3 yrs



38

Shape Hunt

NEEDS Just you

👤 From 30 mo 🔄 Prep 0 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~10 min

Walk around the house looking for circles: a plate, a clock, a wheel. Then hunt for squares.

TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Point and name: "Round, like the clock!"

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

★ 2–3 yrs



39

Little Helper

NEEDS A cloth damp with plain water

👤 From 24 mo 🔄 Prep 1 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~5 min

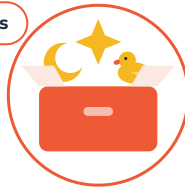
Wipe the table together after a meal. Then let your child wipe a chair, then a toy.

TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Talk as you work: "Wipe, wipe. All clean!"

✓ **With a grown-up.** Plain water only: no sprays or wipes. Stay within reach.

● 3–5 yrs



40

Story Box

NEEDS A box, 3 toys from around the house

👤 From 36 mo 🔄 Prep 2 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~10 min

Pull out 3 toys. Make up a story that uses all three. Take turns adding one sentence each.

TALK TIP · FOLLOW THEIR LEAD

Let the story go anywhere. Ask, "And then what?"

✓ **With a grown-up.** A grown-up plays along and stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs



41

Obstacle Course

NEEDS Pillows, a chair, a blanket

👤 From 36 mo 🔄 Prep 5 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~15 min

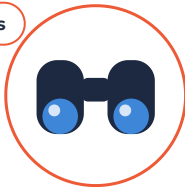
Build a course: crawl under the chair, hop over the pillows, roll across the blanket.

TALK TIP · TAKE TURNS

Give two-step directions: "Crawl under, then jump!" Then swap.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Clear the space of sharp corners. A grown-up stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs



42

I Spy Colors

NEEDS Just you

👤 From 36 mo 🔄 Prep 0 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

"I spy something green." Your child guesses. Then they pick something and give you the clue.

TALK TIP · TAKE TURNS

If they get stuck, add a hint: "It's round..."

✓ **With a grown-up.** A grown-up plays along and stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs



43

Restaurant

NEEDS Paper, crayons, plates

👤 From 36 mo 🔄 Prep 5 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~15 min

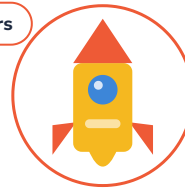
Draw a menu together. Your child takes your order, "cooks" it and brings it to the table. Swap roles.

TALK TIP · OFFER A CHOICE

Ask "Soup or pizza? Anything else?"

✓ **With a grown-up.** A grown-up plays along and stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs



44

Box Rocket

NEEDS A big box, crayons

👤 From 36 mo 🔄 Prep 5 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~15 min

Draw buttons and windows on the box. Climb in, count down from ten, and blast off to the moon.

TALK TIP · FOLLOW THEIR LEAD

Ask "Where are we flying? What's out the window?"

✓ **With a grown-up.** Pull out staples and tape first. A grown-up stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs



45

Kitchen List

NEEDS Paper, a crayon

🕒 From 42 mo 📋 Prep 2 min 🧹 No mess ⌚ ~10 min

Draw a list together: an apple, a cup, a spoon. Hunt for each one in the kitchen and check it off.

TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

“Found the spoon! What’s next on our list?”

✓ **With a grown-up.** You choose the list. Knives, the stove and cleaners stay off it.

● 3–5 yrs



46

Do What I Do

NEEDS Just you

🕒 From 36 mo 📋 Prep 0 min 🧹 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

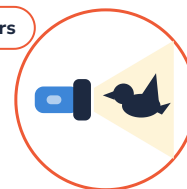
Touch your nose, hop on one foot, spin around once. Your child copies. Then they’re the leader.

TALK TIP · TAKE TURNS

Being the leader means practicing clear directions.

✓ **With a grown-up.** A grown-up plays along and stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs



47

Shadow Animals

NEEDS A flashlight, a wall

🕒 From 36 mo 📋 Prep 2 min 🧹 No mess ⌚ ~10 min

Dim the lights. Shine the flashlight on a wall and make hand shadows: a bird, a dog, a crocodile.

TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT

Ask “What animal is this?” Let them guess, then try a new one.

✓ **With a grown-up.** A grown-up holds the flashlight. Battery covers stay shut.

● 3–5 yrs



48

Book Bridge

NEEDS Books or blocks, toy cars

🕒 From 36 mo 📋 Prep 3 min 🧹 Low mess ⌚ ~10 min

Build a bridge between two stacks. Drive cars over it. Make it longer. Will it hold?

TALK TIP · WONDER ALOUD

Say “I wonder if it will hold?” Then wait and see.

✓ **With a grown-up.** A grown-up plays along and stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs



49

Sock Match

NEEDS A pile of clean socks

🕒 From 36 mo 📋 Prep 1 min 🧹 Low mess ⌚ ~10 min

Dump the socks out. Race to find matching pairs. Roll each pair into a ball.

TALK TIP · OFFER A CHOICE

Hold up two: “Same or different?”

✓ **With a grown-up.** A grown-up plays along and stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs



50

Water Painting

NEEDS A cup of water, a paintbrush

🕒 From 36 mo 📋 Prep 2 min 🧹 Low mess ⌚ ~15 min

Outside, “paint” a fence, a step or the sidewalk with water. Watch the picture dry and disappear.

TALK TIP · WONDER ALOUD

“Where did it go? I wonder if the sun dried it.”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Water play: a grown-up within arm’s reach, away from the street.

● 3–5 yrs



51

Feelings Faces

NEEDS A wall mirror or an unbreakable one

🕒 From 36 mo 📋 Prep 0 min 🧹 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

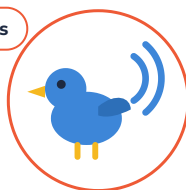
Make faces in the mirror together: happy, sad, surprised, grumpy. Guess each other’s face.

TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

“Your eyebrows went up. Surprised!” Ask when they felt that way.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Use a wall mirror or an unbreakable one. A grown-up stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs



52

Sound Walk

NEEDS A walk outside

🕒 From 36 mo 📋 Prep 0 min 🧹 No mess ⌚ ~15 min

Stand still and listen. Count sounds on your fingers: a bird, a car, the wind. Walk on and listen again.

TALK TIP · TAKE TURNS

Whisper “What do you hear?” Take turns naming sounds.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Hold hands near the street. A grown-up stays close.

MAKE IT YOURS

Your own play

+

TITLE

NEEDS

THE PLAY

TALK TIP

Ages: 0–1 1–2 2–3 3–5



Play & Talk

Cards · Ages 0–5

PLAY BEFORE PIXELS



Play & Talk

Cards · Ages 0–5

PLAY BEFORE PIXELS



Play & Talk

Cards · Ages 0–5

PLAY BEFORE PIXELS



Play & Talk

Cards · Ages 0–5

PLAY BEFORE PIXELS



Play & Talk

Cards · Ages 0–5

PLAY BEFORE PIXELS



Play & Talk

Cards · Ages 0–5

PLAY BEFORE PIXELS



Play & Talk

Cards · Ages 0–5

PLAY BEFORE PIXELS



Play & Talk

Cards · Ages 0–5

PLAY BEFORE PIXELS



Play & Talk

Cards · Ages 0–5

PLAY BEFORE PIXELS

Play & Talk Cards · Make your own: type or write · page 19 of 21 · Version 1.0 · September 2026

Print at Actual size (100%) · cut on the lines · Grown-up keeps the pieces

MAKE IT YOURS Your own play TIT L E NEEDS THE PL AY TALK TIP Ages: 0-1 1-2 2-3 3-5	MAKE IT YOURS Your own play TIT L E NEEDS THE PL AY TALK TIP Ages: 0-1 1-2 2-3 3-5	MAKE IT YOURS Your own play TIT L E NEEDS THE PL AY TALK TIP Ages: 0-1 1-2 2-3 3-5
MAKE IT YOURS Your own play TIT L E NEEDS THE PL AY TALK TIP Ages: 0-1 1-2 2-3 3-5	MAKE IT YOURS Your own play TIT L E NEEDS THE PL AY TALK TIP Ages: 0-1 1-2 2-3 3-5	MAKE IT YOURS Your own play TIT L E NEEDS THE PL AY TALK TIP Ages: 0-1 1-2 2-3 3-5
MAKE IT YOURS Your own play TIT L E NEEDS THE PL AY TALK TIP Ages: 0-1 1-2 2-3 3-5	MAKE IT YOURS Your own play TIT L E NEEDS THE PL AY TALK TIP Ages: 0-1 1-2 2-3 3-5	MAKE IT YOURS Your own play TIT L E NEEDS THE PL AY TALK TIP Ages: 0-1 1-2 2-3 3-5

Our Play & Talk Year

One card a week is plenty. Check it off when you've played it, and color in the heart if your child asks for it again.

▲ 0-1 year	■ 1-2 years	★ 2-3 years	● 3-5 years
☐ 01 Peekaboo Cloth ☐ ♥	☐ 14 Box Car ☐ ♥	☐ 27 Blanket Fort ☐ ♥	☐ 40 Story Box ☐ ♥
☐ 02 Copy Cat Faces ☐ ♥	☐ 15 Stir the Soup ☐ ♥	☐ 28 Tea Party ☐ ♥	☐ 41 Obstacle Course ☐ ♥
☐ 03 Kitchen Drum ☐ ♥	☐ 16 Animal Voices ☐ ♥	☐ 29 Color Sort ☐ ♥	☐ 42 I Spy Colors ☐ ♥
☐ 04 Where's Duck? ☐ ♥	☐ 17 Pour and Splash ☐ ♥	☐ 30 Car Ramp ☐ ♥	☐ 43 Restaurant ☐ ♥
☐ 05 Bubble Watch ☐ ♥	☐ 18 Block Tower ☐ ♥	☐ 31 Big Paper Art ☐ ♥	☐ 44 Box Rocket ☐ ♥
☐ 06 Rock and Stop ☐ ♥	☐ 19 Hat Parade ☐ ♥	☐ 32 Freeze Dance ☐ ♥	☐ 45 Kitchen List ☐ ♥
☐ 07 Roll It Back ☐ ♥	☐ 20 Pillow Mountain ☐ ♥	☐ 33 Sock Friend Chat ☐ ♥	☐ 46 Do What I Do ☐ ♥
☐ 08 First Book Chat ☐ ♥	☐ 21 Sock Toss ☐ ♥	☐ 34 Nature Basket ☐ ♥	☐ 47 Shadow Animals ☐ ♥
☐ 09 In and Out ☐ ♥	☐ 22 Teddy's Bedtime ☐ ♥	☐ 35 Pretend Shop ☐ ♥	☐ 48 Book Bridge ☐ ♥
☐ 10 Leaf Hello ☐ ♥	☐ 23 Chair Tunnel ☐ ♥	☐ 36 Toy Bath ☐ ♥	☐ 49 Sock Match ☐ ♥
☐ 11 Tickle Countdown ☐ ♥	☐ 24 Clap and Stomp ☐ ♥	☐ 37 Animal Moves ☐ ♥	☐ 50 Water Painting ☐ ♥
☐ 12 Stack and Crash ☐ ♥	☐ 25 Pull-Out Box ☐ ♥	☐ 38 Shape Hunt ☐ ♥	☐ 51 Feelings Faces ☐ ♥
☐ 13 Sock Off! ☐ ♥	☐ 26 Kick and Chase ☐ ♥	☐ 39 Little Helper ☐ ♥	☐ 52 Sound Walk ☐ ♥

Our favorite play so far:

A new word, sign or sound we noticed:



Play Before Pixels Play Before Pixels

What's next

Thank you for playing first

Your files stay on your Etsy Purchases page, ready to download again any time. Open them in a web browser, not the app, and save them to Files or your computer.

Share a photo of your fridge checklist or your favorite card: sharing is always optional.

Next for your family



"I'm Bored" Play Cards

Ages 1–5 · 76 play cards in two age bands, each with a talk prompt



Toddler Busy Book

Ages 1–5 · 74 printable activities for waiting rooms, car rides and quiet time



100 Screen-Free Plays

Ages 0–5 · the activity book, sorted by age, with a talk line on every play

Find them all in our shop, **Play Before Pixels**. Bundles are offered at a fair discount.

Which card did your family love?

A short, honest review on the shop where you bought this helps other families decide. Questions or ideas? Send us a message through Etsy.



52 Play & Talk Cards, Ages 0–5. Version 1.0 · September 2026. Printable PDF for personal and family use.

Parent education only. These cards are ideas for everyday play and conversation; they are not medical, developmental or professional advice and are not a substitute for care from a qualified professional. Always supervise children during play.

© 2026 AlphaPlay LLC. Play Before Pixels is a trade name of AlphaPlay LLC. All rights reserved. License: personal/family use only; full terms in the shop's listing and policies.